

Toddler Positive Phase — Action Checklist

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UNDERSTAND YOUR TODDLER'S BRAIN

- ☐ **Understand the Brain Science:** Accept that your toddler's prefrontal cortex is still developing, which means they literally cannot process negative commands the way adults can, so stop interpreting their responses as deliberate defiance.
- ☐ **Catch Your Tension:** Notice the moments when you approach your toddler already expecting a fight, because that tension gets transmitted to them and triggers the exact escalation you were trying to prevent.
- ☐ **Shift Your Focus:** Move your goal from becoming a perfectly calm parent to simply changing two things — the words you use and the environment you set up around your toddler.
- ☐ **Recognize the Feedback Loop:** Identify how your expectation of conflict creates a self-fulfilling cycle where your stress triggers your toddler's stress, which triggers more corrections from you, and break that cycle by changing your first input.

MASTER POSITIVE REDIRECTION

- ☐ **Use the 3-Part Redirection:** Structure every redirection with what you want them to do, a brief reason when appropriate, and what they can do instead, so they always have a clear action to take rather than just something to stop.
- ☐ **Pick One Phrase and Practice:** Select a single positive redirection phrase from the guide tables and use it consistently for three full days before adding another phrase, because sustainable change comes from mastery, not overwhelm.
- ☐ **Diagnose Failed Redirections:** When a phrase stops working, systematically check whether the environment still has the temptation, the transition happened too quickly without warning, or your toddler's basic needs like food or sleep are unmet.
- ☐ **Give Two-Minute Warnings:** Before ending any activity or transitioning to something new, tell your toddler in advance so their brain has time to process the upcoming change instead of being caught off guard.

DESIGN A YES SPACE ENVIRONMENT

- ☐ **Create a Yes Space:** Designate one room or area where everything is toddler-safe and toddler-appropriate so you never have to say no in that space, allowing your toddler to explore freely and you to stay relaxed.
 - ☐ **Childproof the Yes Space:** Cover all outlets, anchor heavy furniture to walls, remove small choking hazards, ensure nothing toxic is within reach, and add a low shelf with independently accessible toys.
 - ☐ **Offer Binary Choices Outside the Space:** When you need cooperation outside the yes space, give your toddler a choice between two acceptable options like the red shirt or blue shirt, which gives them autonomy while keeping you in control of the outcome.
 - ☐ **Set Up for Easy Supervision:** Arrange the yes space so you can see your toddler at all times without needing to constantly intervene, correcting, or redirect, which reduces your stress and allows genuine connection.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.